a lot of credit needs to go to Major Oscar Thomas for bringing the unit back with relatively few losses. Some of the courageous Punjabis also made it back, but their losses were much higher.

A FORTRESS CALLED TAWANG

Moving westwards from the Bhutan-India-Tibet junction, the first route into India from Tibet was through Khenzemane along the Nyamjang Chu. The next point of entry, approximately three days' march to the east, was Bum-la, which was the preferred crossing point for traders. This track linked Tawang to Tsona Dzong and was the shorter route to Tawang from Tibet. Heavy snowfall would result in Bum-la closing down for the winter months, forcing any movement then to take place only through Khenzemane and the mule track that proceeded south downriver along the Nyamjang Chu to Zimithang before turning east to go to Tawang.

Until the fateful morning of 20 October, the Indian high command seemed so intent on events in and around the Nam Ka Chu Valley and the Thagla Ridge, that everything else had been more or less ignored. The defence of Tawang and the Kameng Sector had been left in the charge of Brigadier Kalyan Singh, commander of the artillery brigade. On 19 October, Kalyan Singh had arrived at Zimithang to meet General Prasad and had since got caught up in the fast-developing scenario. Niranjan Prasad's reluctance to relocate to Tawang the moment the Chinese attacked was understandable, but it was vital to have sent Kalyan Singh back post-haste. However, with both the helicopters lost, it would take the GOC of the division and the commander of the garrison, Kalyan Singh, the better part of two days to walk back to Tawang.

Ever since 8 September, when the Chinese had appeared at the Dhola post, all the carefully laid plans that were a part of the build-up for Op Onkar had been abandoned. With the diversion of 7 Brigade to the Nam Ka Chu Valley, Tawang, which until then had been declared a 'vital area', was left with just 1 Sikh with 7 Bengal Mountain Battery in support to man its defences. With hardly any real force levels under his ad hoc command, Kalyan Singh could do little other than await additional troops that had been promised to him. By 8 October, the Tawang garrison got a major boost with the arrival of 4 Garhwal Rifles and another mountain battery. This was further reinforced when 97 Field Battery with their 25-pounder guns and a troop of 4.2-inch mortars joined them.